LESSON 6: COMMUNICATION IN THE CLASSROOM

6.1 Introduction

Welcome to our seventh lesson on communication in the classroom. Communication is the imparting or exchanging of information by speaking, writing, or using some other medium. It is important to note that the art of teaching majorly is made possible through communication. Teaching is the imparting of knowledge, skills and positive attitude to learners and this is made possible through communication. Actually, one of the most important skills of a good teacher is good communication skills**.** Communicating effectively with students creates a positive learning environment and fosters student success. Good communication skills by the teacher also enable teachers to build strong relationships with students, parents, and colleagues. As teachers or instructors, there is need for successful conveying or sharing of ideas and feelings during teaching and learning process making communication an important ingredient for the same. In this lesson we shall define communication, look at the types of communication, process of communication, communication channels, communication flows and importance and need for effective communication for teachers and managers. Welcome to the lesson.

6.2 Lesson learning outcomes

By the end of this lesson, learners should be able to:

6.2.1 Explain the concept of communication

6.2.2 Describe the various types of communication

6.2.3 Explain the process of communication

6.2.4 Appreciate the importance of communication to teachers

6.2.1 Concept of communication

The root of the word "communication" in Latin is *communicare*, which means to share, or to make common. Communication is simply the act of transferring information from one place, person or group to another. Communication is the act of sharing and receiving information through a variety of media to various individuals. The term communication requires an element of success in transmitting or imparting a message, whether information, ideas, or emotions. Communication is a process by which information is exchanged between individuals through a common system of symbols, signs, or behavior. It is the exchange of meanings between individuals through a common system of symbols. Every communication involves (at least) one sender, a message and a recipient. This may sound simple, but communication is actually a very complex subject. The transmission of the message from sender to recipient can be affected by a huge range of things. These include our emotions, the cultural situation, the medium used to communicate, and even our location. As this definition makes clear, communication is more than simply the transmission of information.

6.2.2 Types of Communication

There are three types of communication, including: verbal communication involving listening to a person to understand the meaning of a message, written communication in which a message is read, and nonverbal communication involving observing a person and inferring meaning. Let's start with verbal communication, which is the most common form of communication.

Verbal Communication

Verbal communications in business take place over the phone or in person. . Normally, a verbal communication takes place in real time. Verbal communication includes face-to-face, telephone, radio or television and other media.

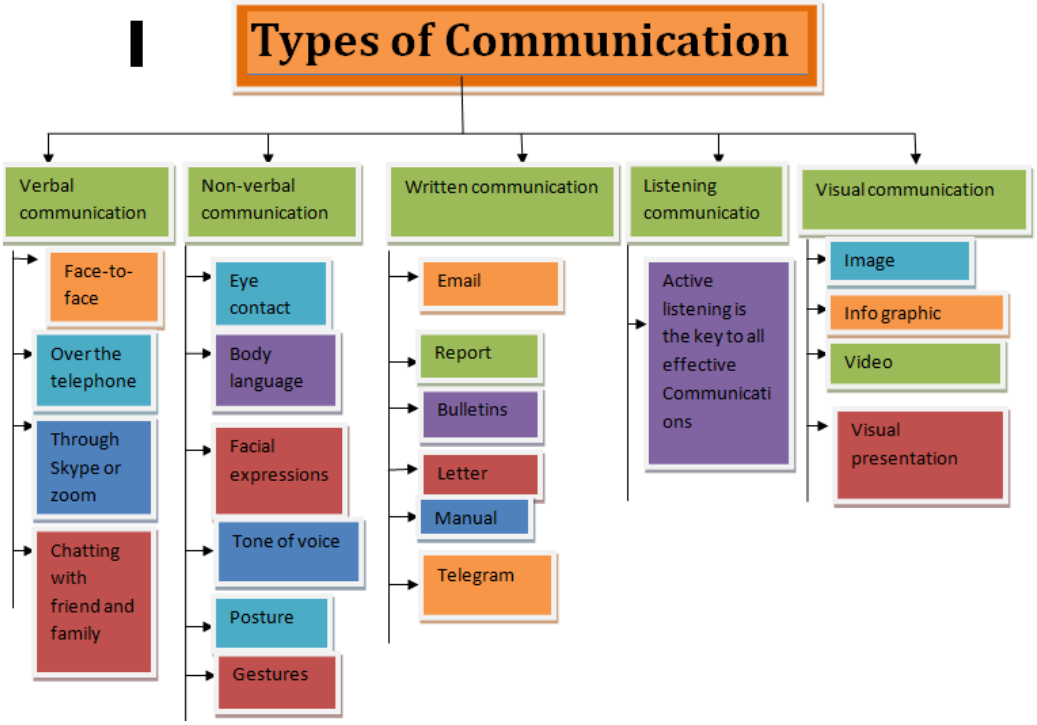
Nonverbal Communication

This is communication using non verbal cues covering body language, gestures, how we dress or act, where we stand, and even our scent. There are many subtle ways that we communicate (perhaps even unintentionally) with others. For example, the tone of voice can give clues to mood or emotional state, whilst hand signals or gestures can add to a spoken message. Some of the examples of nonverbal communication include body language, eye contact, facial expressions, posture, touch and space.

Written Communication

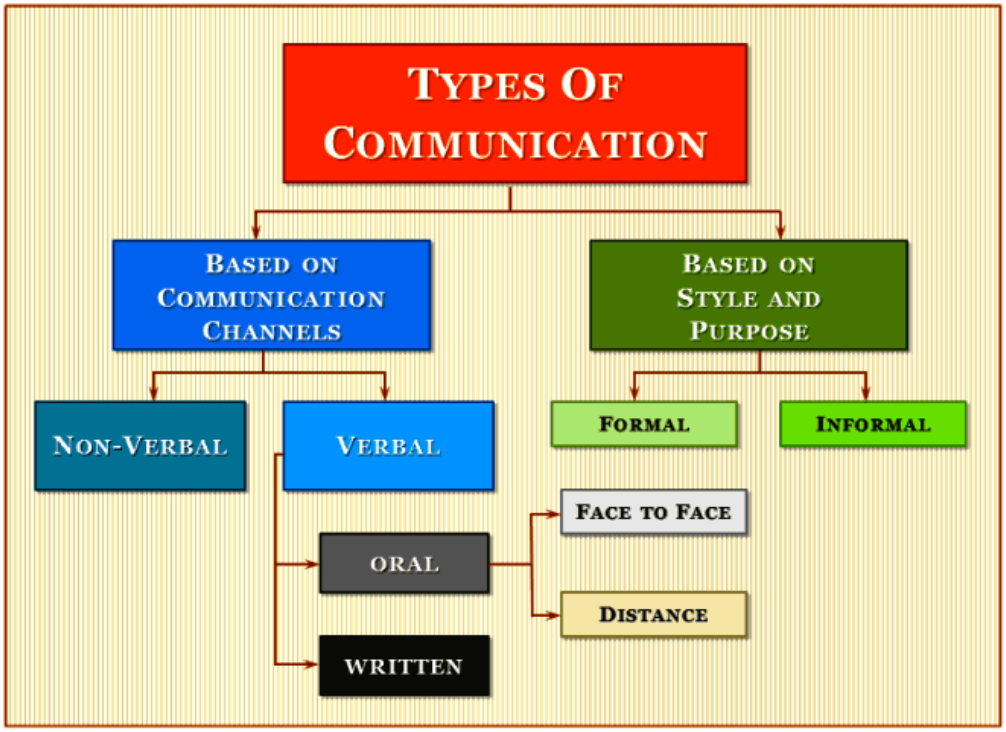
In contrast to verbal communications, which are oral, written business communications are printed messages. Examples of written communications include memos, proposals, e-mails, letters, training manuals, and operating policies. They may be printed on paper or appear on the screen. Written communication, by contrast, can be constructed over a longer period of time. It also can be collaborative. Multiple people can contribute to the content on one document before that document is sent to the intended audience. Written communication includes letters, e-mails, social media, books, magazines, the Internet and other media. Until recent times, a relatively small number of writers and publishers were very powerful when it came to communicating the written word. Today, we can all write and publish our ideas online, which has led to an explosion of information and communication possibilities.

Figure1 Types of communication



Types of communication can also be viewed based on communication channel or based on style and purpose as shown below

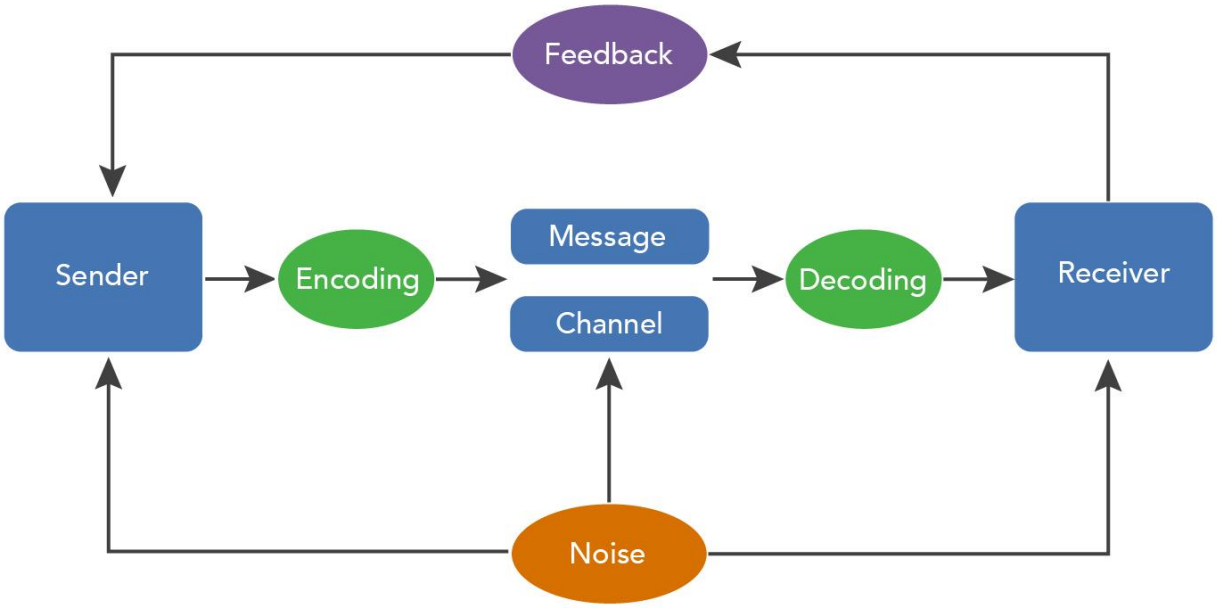
Figure 2 Types of communication based communication channel or based on style and purpose



6.2.3 Process of communication

Communication is a process between at least two people that begins when one person wants to communicate with another. Communication originates as mental images within a person who desires to convey those images to another. The communication process is made up of four key components. Those components include encoding, medium of transmission, decoding, and feedback. There are also two other factors in the process, and those two factors are present in the form of the sender and the receiver. Below is a diagrammatic representation of the communication process.

Figure 3 Communication model



The sender is the source of information. The sender imagines, creates, and sends the message. In a public speaking situation, the source is the person giving the speech. He or she conveys the message by sharing new information with the audience. In order to convey meaning, the sender must begin encoding, which means translating information into a message in the form of symbols that represent ideas or concepts. This process translates the ideas or concepts into the coded message that will be communicated. The symbols can take on numerous forms such as, languages, words, or gestures. These symbols are used to encode ideas into messages that others can understand.

When encoding a message, the sender has to begin by deciding what he/she wants to transmit. This decision by the sender is based on what he/she believes about the receivers knowledge and assumptions, along with what additional information he/she wants the receiver to have. It is important for the sender to use symbols that are familiar to the intended receiver. A good way for the sender to improve encoding their message, is to mentally visualize the communication from the receiver's point of view.

To begin transmitting the message, the sender uses some kind of channel (also called a medium). The channel is the means used to convey the message. Most channels are either oral or written, but currently visual channels are becoming more common as technology expands. Common channels include the telephone and a variety of written forms such as memos, letters, and reports. The effectiveness of the various channels fluctuates depending on the characteristics of the communication. For example, when immediate feedback is necessary, oral communication channels are more effective because any uncertainties can be cleared up on the spot. In a situation where the message must be delivered to more than a small group of people, written channels are often more effective. Although in many cases, both oral and written channels should be used because one supplements the other.

If a sender relays a message through an inappropriate channel, its message may not reach the right receivers. That is why senders need to keep in mind that selecting the appropriate channel will greatly assist in the effectiveness of the receiver's understanding. The sender's decision to utilize either an oral or a written channel for communicating a message is influenced by several factors. The sender should ask him or herself different questions, so that they can select the appropriate channel.

Is the message urgent?

Is immediate feedback needed?

Is documentation or a permanent record required?

Is the content complicated, controversial, or private?

Is the message going to someone inside or outside the organization?

What oral and written communication skills does the receiver possess?

Once the sender has answered all of these questions, they will be able to choose an effective channel.

After the appropriate channel or channels are selected, the message enters the decoding stage of the communication process. Decoding is conducted by the receiver. Once the message is received and examined, the stimulus is sent to the brain for interpreting, in order to assign some type of meaning to it. It is this processing stage that constitutes decoding. The receiver begins to interpret the symbols sent by the sender, translating the message to their own set of experiences in order to make the symbols meaningful. Successful communication takes place when the receiver correctly interprets the sender's message.

The receiver is the individual or individuals to whom the message is directed. The extent to which this person comprehends the message will depend on a number of factors, which include the following: how much the individual or individuals know about the topic, their receptivity to the message, and the relationship and trust that exists between sender and receiver. All interpretations by the receiver are influenced by their experiences, attitudes, knowledge, skills, perceptions, and culture. It is similar to the sender's relationship with encoding.

Feedback is the final link in the chain of the communication process. After receiving a message, the receiver responds in some way and signals that response to the sender. The signal may take the form of a spoken comment, a long sigh, a written message, a smile, or some other action. Even a lack of response, is in a sense, a form of response. Without feedback, the sender cannot confirm that the receiver has interpreted the message correctly.

Feedback is a key component in the communication process because it allows the sender to evaluate the effectiveness of the message. Feedback ultimately provides an opportunity for the sender to take corrective action to clarify a misunderstood message. Feedback plays an important

role by indicating significant communication barriers: differences in background, different interpretations of words, and differing emotional reactions.

The communication process is the perfect guide toward achieving effective communication. When followed properly, the process can usually assure that the sender's message will be understood by the receiver.

Although the communication process seems simple, it in essence is not. Certain barriers present themselves throughout the process. Those barriers are factors that have a negative impact on the communication process. Some common barriers include the use of an inappropriate medium (channel), incorrect grammar, inflammatory words, words that conflict with body language, and technical jargon.

Noise is also another common barrier. Noise is the term given to anything that disrupts the communication. That is, anything that prevents the audience from receiving the message the way they source intended to. It doesn't necessarily involve and audible distraction. Noise can occur during any stage of the process. Noise essentially is anything that distorts a message by interfering with the communication process. Noise can take many forms, including a radio playing in the background, another person trying to enter your conversation, and any other distractions that prevent the receiver from paying attention.

Successful and effective communication within an organization stems from the implementation of the communication process. All members within an organization will improve their communication skills if they follow the communication process, and stay away from the different barriers. It has been proven that individuals that understand the communication process will blossom into more effective communicators, and effective communicators have a greater opportunity for becoming a success.

Communication Flows in an Organization

In an organization, communication flows in 5 main directions namely, downward, upward, lateral, diagonal and external

1. **Downward Flow of Communication:** Communication that flows from a higher level in an organization to a lower level is a downward communication. In other words, communication from for example the principal to members of staff in a chain of command is a downward communication.
2. **Upward Flow of Communication:** Communication that flows to a higher level in an organization is called upward communication. It provides feedback on how well the organization is functioning. The members of staff use upward communication to convey their problems and performances to their principals or departmental heads.
3. **Lateral / Horizontal Communication:** Communication that takes place at same levels of hierarchy in an organization is called lateral communication, i.e., communication between

peers, between heads of departments at same levels or between any horizontally equivalent organizational member.

4. **Diagonal Communication:** Communication that takes place between for example the principal and employees of other stakeholders is called diagonal communication. It generally does not appear on organizational chart.
5. **External Communication:** Communication that takes place between for example a principal and external groups such as - suppliers, banks, financial institutes etc.

6.2.4 Importance of good communication in teaching and learning process

Good communication skills are essential for teachers. They need to be able to communicate effectively with their students and other teachers, and school staff. Good communication skills can help teachers to better understand their students and to build positive relationships with them. In addition, good communication skills can help teachers resolve conflicts and manage their classrooms effectively.

Teachers need to be able to communicate with students and parents. Good communication skills are important for the success of any teaching profession. In this article, we explore why it is necessary to have good communication skills and some other ways teachers can improve their effectiveness in delivering instruction and educating students.

Teaching is all about communication - listening, speaking, reading, presenting and writing. Teachers who hone their communication skills are prepared to instruct, advise and mentor students entrusted in their care. Additionally, teachers must communicate well to effectively collaborate with colleagues and update administrators on student progress.

Communication is both receptive and expressive. Teachers must be skilled at listening to their students as well as explaining things clearly. Teachers need clarity of thought to present the material. They must be able to break down complex ideas into simpler parts and smaller steps to transmit to their students. They must be able to adapt their methods of communication to all students regardless of ability or learning style. They are able to "read" their students and adapt to the needs of the individual. Effective communication includes transforming the boring into the interesting and having good presentation skills.

Good teachers communicate concern and caring by their tone of voice and use of body language. They transmit genuine commitment and affection for their students. Good teachers care about their students' progress and let their students know it at all times. They learn their students' names early in the school year and use their names when addressing them. They get to know their students' hopes, fears and preferences and communicate this knowledge to their students. They communicate their appreciation for what their students do by celebrating their successes and constantly encouraging them. This helps students feel recognized and validated.

Although teaching is often done in the isolation of a classroom without the presence of other adults, good teaching involves consultation with colleagues. Schools that see themselves as professional learning communities encourage teachers to plan lessons together and learn from one another. They take a team approach when problem-solving, especially for difficult students. This all requires excellent communication. Teachers stay abreast of new developments in education by reading journals, listening to new ideas from their administrators and school board consultants, and sharing and discussing these ideas with colleagues.

Assessment

Q1. What are 5 good communication skills?

A1. Five good communication skills are written communication skills, oral communication skills, non-verbal communication, contextual communication, and active listening.

Q2. What makes a good communicator?

Answer: A good communicator is made by practice and some tips such as choice of words, creating a connection with the audience, and understanding their audience.

Q3. Why is communication important?

Answer: Communication is important because it helps to make connections with people and understand them. It helps to communicate our needs and wants.

Q4. What is the most important communication skill?

Answer: The most important communication skill is listening. A person that does not listen to the other person can never do effective communication.

Q5. What are the greatest challenges to good communication?

Answer: The greatest challenges to good communication are the irrelevance of the receiver, lack of attention, distractions, and interest.

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